

D.K. SHIVAKUMAR (DKS)

The Karnataka PCC chief, eight-time MLA and party's go-to troubleshooter. Led from the front and rejuvenated the party

M.B. PATIL

A topline Lingayat leader and Siddaramaiah confidant, the state campaign committee chief organised all the roadshows, public meetings and door-to-door campaigns in the state





SUNIL KANUGOLU

The poll strategist devised separate campaign strategies for each constituency. Also worked out campaigns on themes like PayCM etc. to corner the BJP



GOURAV VALLABH

The party national spokesperson led the fight in the TV debates, amplifying the 40% commission charge and *parivar-vaad* in the BJP, pointing to 34 candidates in the fray

SIDDARAMAIAH

The former Karnataka CM and prominent backward class leader, along with DKS, led the poll campaign in the state





PRIYANK KHARGE

Kharge Sr's son and three-time MLA from Chittapur was a vital cog in bringing in the Scheduled Caste votes. As state communications in-charge, brought a local flavour to the campaign



SASIKANTH SENTHIL

The ex-IAS officer who joined the Congress in 2020 was in charge of the election war room. Also led the social media charge against the BJP

and print them with the signatures and photographs of Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar, with space left for the voter's name and address. Senthil was then entrusted with the task of ensuring that they reached most of the households in the state. Among the methods he employed was to get together all aspirants in a particular constituency, divide the households among them and go door-to-door to hand over the cards. Senthil told them their chances of getting a ticket depended on their performance in this outreach. A separate mechanism and database were set up to check whether a household got the guarantee card. They revealed that an average of over 50 per cent of the households in each constituency were covered.

Key Congress campaigners were also told to emphasise in each speech that the guarantees would be implemented the day a Congress government was sworn in. Once the election was announced, the Congress added a fifth guarantee. Called Shakti, it promised free travel to all women in regular Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation and Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation buses. The BJP attacked the five guarantees, saying they would push the state into bankruptcy. The Congress claimed they would cost the exchequer around Rs 50,000 crore, or less than 20 per cent of the budgetary expenditure. The party promised to boost revenue generation to meet the additional expenses of the schemes.

Most voters in the state, particularly the poor, seemed happy with the guarantees. The INDIA TODAY-AMI exit poll showed that a high 10 per cent of those who voted for the Congress cited the party's welfare promises as the reason; the Congress's subregion-wise seat share was the highest in the state's poorest regions. The Congress also did exceptionally well among voters with income less than Rs 10,000 a month. With most of the Congress guarantees targeted towards women, the the number of women who voted for the Congress was 11 percentage points higher than for the BJP, as per the exit poll. Gupta says more than the common man, it was the common woman who favoured the Congress, and that became one of the main reasons for the party's spectacular victory. Even among males, the Congress vote was five percentage points higher than for the BJP.

LESSON 5: BREAKING THE CASTE BARRIER

The Congress was aware that to win a comfortable majority in Karnataka, it would require all communities on the caste spectrum to vote for it. In 2013, when the party had won a majority in the assembly, Siddaramaiah, who is from the Kuruba backward class, had revived a 1970s-vintage social compound called Ahinda, a catch-all Kannada acronym for a combination of the Alpasankhyataru or minorities, Hindulidavaru or backward classes, and Dalitaru or Dalits, who together constitute nearly 40 per cent of the state's population. What it needed to do this time was to also reach out to the two dominant communities—the Lingayats, who traditionally sided with the